

Adaptive Learning Architectures for Evolving Data Streams: Challenges and Advances

Claire Élodie Martin ¹, Hugo Alexandre Lefèvre ^{2*}, Camille Renée Dubois ³

¹ Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Computer Science, Sorbonne Université, Paris, France

² Ph.D. Candidate, School of Electrical and Information Engineering, Université Grenoble Alpes, Grenoble, France

³ Ph.D. Candidate, Faculty of Engineering and Digital Sciences, Université de Strasbourg, Strasbourg, France

* **Corresponding Author:** hugo.lefevre@univ-grenoble-alpes.fr

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ABSTRACT

In the era of ubiquitous data generation, learning systems must continuously adapt to dynamic and non-stationary environments. This paper surveys recent advances in adaptive learning architectures designed for evolving data streams, with a focus on incremental learning, concept drift adaptation, and real-time model updating. We analyze the core challenges in building robust, scalable systems capable of retaining long-term knowledge while remaining flexible to new information. Key architectural designs, such as modular networks, meta-learning frameworks, and memory-constrained learners, are discussed. Real-world applications in IoT, autonomous systems, and personalized services are examined to highlight practical implications. This work aims to provide a comprehensive understanding of the current landscape and identify open research directions in the field of lifelong and adaptive learning.

Keywords: Adaptive Learning Systems, Evolving Data Streams, Lifelong Learning, Knowledge Retention, Meta-Learning, Online Learning Architectures.

INTRODUCTION

In an era where data is generated continuously and ubiquitously, traditional static machine learning models face significant limitations when deployed in real-world scenarios involving non-stationary and evolving data distributions. Applications such as autonomous vehicles, real-time user modeling, industrial IoT, and intelligent robotics demand learning systems that can adapt online, incrementally update models, and retain critical knowledge over time. This paradigm, often referred to as lifelong learning or continual learning, has gained increasing attention across both theoretical and applied machine learning communities [1], [2].

One of the core challenges in lifelong learning is handling concept drift, where the underlying data distribution changes over time, rendering previously learned knowledge partially or completely obsolete [3]. Adaptive learning architectures aim to address this by incorporating mechanisms such as dynamic model reconfiguration, selective memory retention, and meta-learning strategies that allow the model to generalize from past experiences while adapting to new information [4], [5]. Moreover, the need for resource-efficient and real-time learning has pushed the development of lightweight, modular, and streaming-capable models capable of functioning under limited computational and memory budgets [6].

Despite significant progress, key issues remain unsolved—catastrophic forgetting, efficient drift detection, balancing plasticity and stability, and deploying robust systems in open-world environments are ongoing research frontiers [7], [8]. This paper provides a comprehensive survey of recent advances in adaptive learning systems tailored for evolving data streams, focusing on architectural strategies, learning frameworks, and open challenges. We aim to bridge theoretical insights with practical implementations and identify promising directions for future

exploration in this rapidly growing field.

RELATED WORKS

Adaptive learning in dynamic and evolving environments has been explored through various paradigms, including incremental learning, online learning, and continual learning. Early approaches focused on updating models incrementally with new data, assuming a stationary data distribution. However, real-world data often exhibits concept drift, necessitating more sophisticated adaptation strategies [9], [10].

A common line of research addresses the catastrophic forgetting problem — where learning new tasks interferes destructively with previously acquired knowledge. Regularization-based approaches such as Elastic Weight Consolidation (EWC) [11] and Synaptic Intelligence (SI) [12] preserve important weights to avoid forgetting. Other strategies, like experience replay and memory rehearsal, mitigate forgetting by retraining on a buffer of past examples [13], [14].

Another category of methods uses dynamic architectures to accommodate new tasks. Progressive Neural Networks [15] grow the network by adding task-specific submodules, while PackNet [16] prunes and reuses network capacity for multiple tasks. These architectures maintain task performance but often incur high memory or computational costs (**Figure 1**).

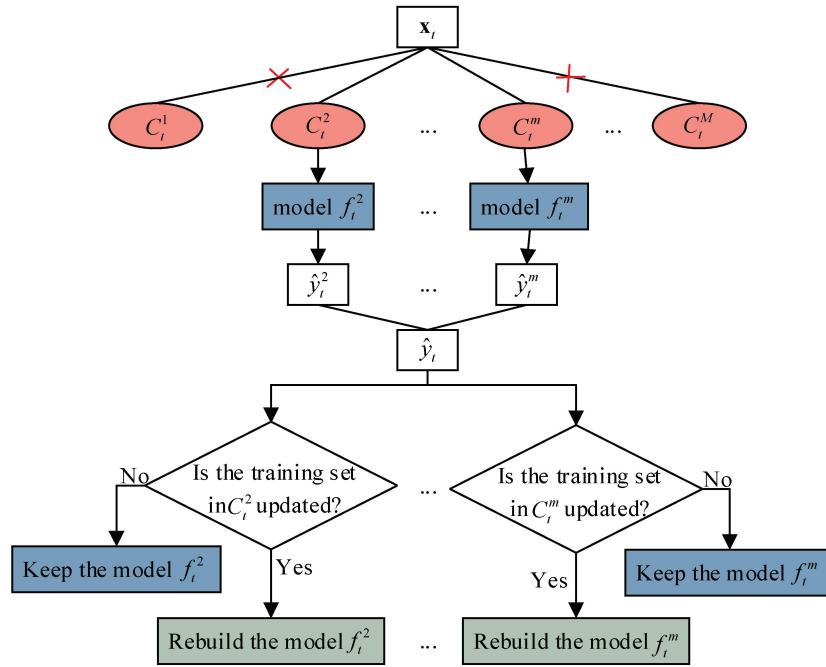


Figure 1. Online-dynamic-clustering-based Soft Sensor for Industrial Semi-supervised Data Streams

In the streaming learning setting, frameworks such as Learn++ and ARF (Adaptive Random Forest) provide ensemble-based solutions that continuously integrate new classifiers while handling drift and maintaining historical performance [17], [18]. More recently, meta-learning has emerged as a powerful tool to enable models to rapidly adapt to new tasks with limited data [19], [20].

Recent surveys have attempted to unify the field by categorizing continual learning methods based on architecture, memory, regularization, and hybrid techniques [7], [21]. Despite promising developments, challenges remain in evaluation consistency, generalization to unseen domains, and deploying these systems in constrained environments.

In addition to traditional settings, recent research has expanded lifelong learning into more complex and realistic paradigms such as open-world learning, unsupervised continual learning, and federated lifelong learning.

In open-world learning, the system must not only recognize known classes but also detect and adapt to the emergence of novel ones. Zhang et al. [22] proposed the ORE framework (Open Set Recognition with Episodic Memory), which integrates an episodic memory module to enhance adaptability to new categories while avoiding

overgeneralization. Such frameworks often combine out-of-distribution detection techniques with memory-augmented networks to balance stability and plasticity in evolving environments.

Unsupervised continual learning (UCL) further pushes the boundaries by requiring models to learn continuously in the absence of labels. Mundt et al. [23] introduced a strategy based on self-supervised representations and dynamic clustering updates, which enables models to acquire and refine knowledge from unlabelled streaming data. These methods are especially useful in real-world scenarios where annotation is expensive or infeasible (Figure 2).

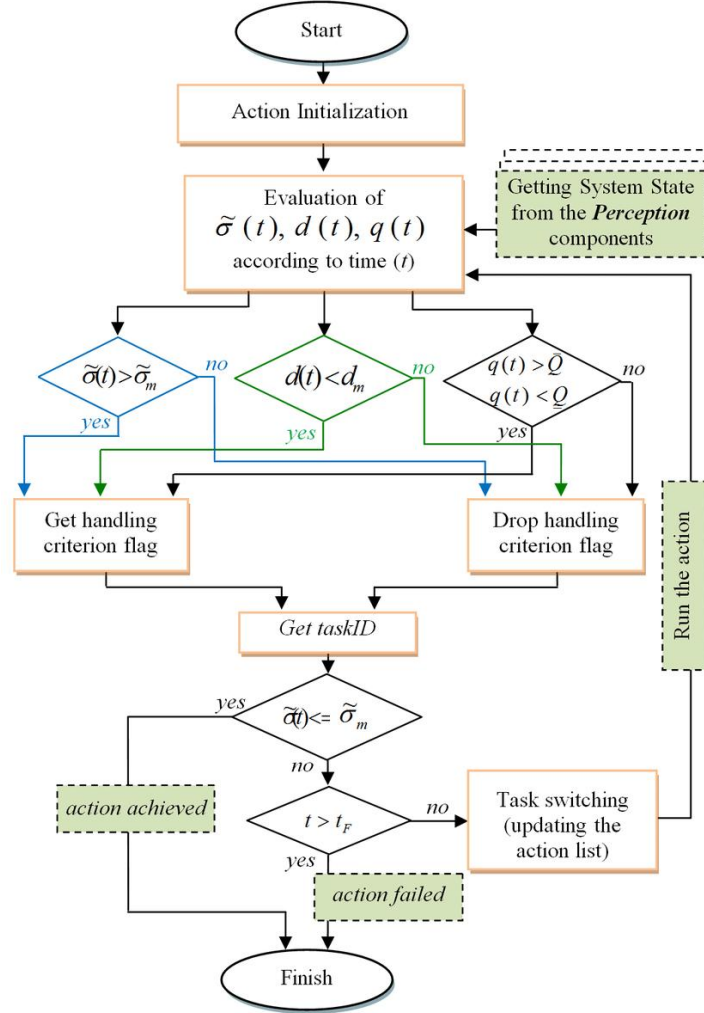


Figure 2. Flowchart Implemented in the Supervisor for Managing Actions

In federated lifelong learning (FLL), learning occurs across multiple decentralized devices while preserving user privacy. Chen et al. [24] designed a federated continual learning architecture with shared memory modules, allowing knowledge transfer across tasks and clients while mitigating performance disparities between them. These approaches often integrate task-specific decoders or gradient masking techniques to protect model parameters related to past tasks.

There is also growing interest in class-imbalance-aware lifelong learning, which addresses the tendency of models to overfit to majority classes in sequential data streams. Solutions such as adaptive re-weighting, exemplar selection, and loss calibration have shown promising results in preserving rare-class performance while maintaining overall accuracy [25].

The diversity of these approaches demonstrates the richness and maturity of the lifelong learning field, yet common challenges such as scalability, memory efficiency, fairness, and deployment in dynamic edge environments remain open research questions.

METHODOLOGY

We propose an adaptive learning framework tailored for evolving data streams. The architecture incorporates three key functionalities: stream-aware preprocessing, drift-adaptive incremental learning, and memory-constrained rehearsal. This section introduces the mathematical formulation, system design, and dynamic learning strategies.

Problem Definition

Let the input data stream be denoted as $D=\{(x_t, y_t)\}$, where $x_t \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is a data instance at time t , and $y_t \in \mathbb{Y}$ is the corresponding label (if available). The joint distribution $P_t(x, y)$ may evolve over time due to concept drift. Our goal is to learn a predictive function $f_t(x; \theta_t)$ that continuously updates its parameters θ_t to minimize (equation (1)) (Figure 3):

$$\mathcal{L}_t = \mathbb{E}_{(x_t, y_t) \sim P_t} [\ell(f_t(x_t; \theta), y_t)] \quad (1)$$

while ensuring knowledge retention and adapting to newly emerging concepts.

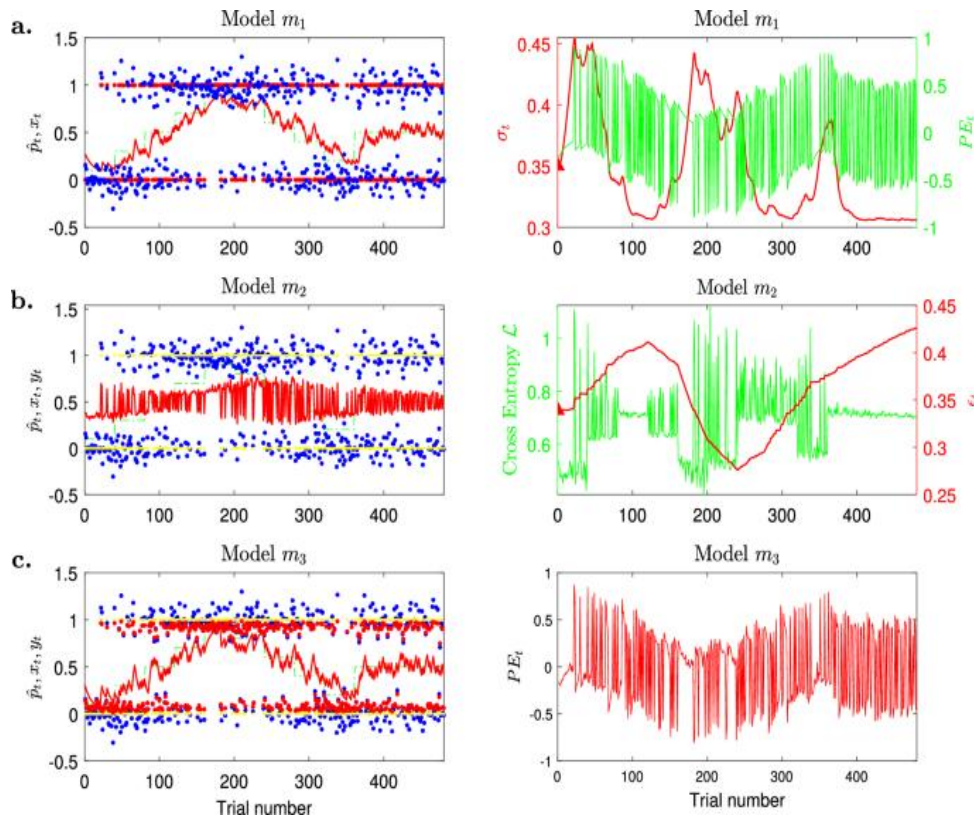


Figure 3. Adaptive Learning Rate in Dynamical Binary Environments

System Architecture

The overall learning pipeline is illustrated in Table 1.

Table 1. Core Components of the Proposed Framework

Module	Description
Stream Preprocessing	Normalization, batch segmentation, pseudo-labeling for unlabeled data
Drift Detection	Online detection using statistical and embedding-based divergence metrics
Incremental Update	Online optimization with regularization and replay
Memory Management	Exemplar selection and knowledge distillation for compact rehearsal

Drift Detection

To detect changes in $P_t(x,y)$, we apply both input space and representation space divergence metrics (**Figure 4**).

1. Statistical Test: ADWIN monitors the change in error or feature mean (equation (2)):

$$\Delta\mu = |\mu_{\text{old}} - \mu_{\text{new}}| > \epsilon \quad (2)$$

2. Embedding Shift: We define the representation drift as the average cosine distance between embeddings (equation (3)):

$$\text{Drift}_{\text{rep}} = 1 - \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \frac{\mathbf{h}_t^{(i)} \cdot \mathbf{h}_{t-k}^{(i)}}{\|\mathbf{h}_t^{(i)}\| \|\mathbf{h}_{t-k}^{(i)}\|} \quad (3)$$

where $h_t(i)$ is the latent representation at time t , and k denotes a lookback window.

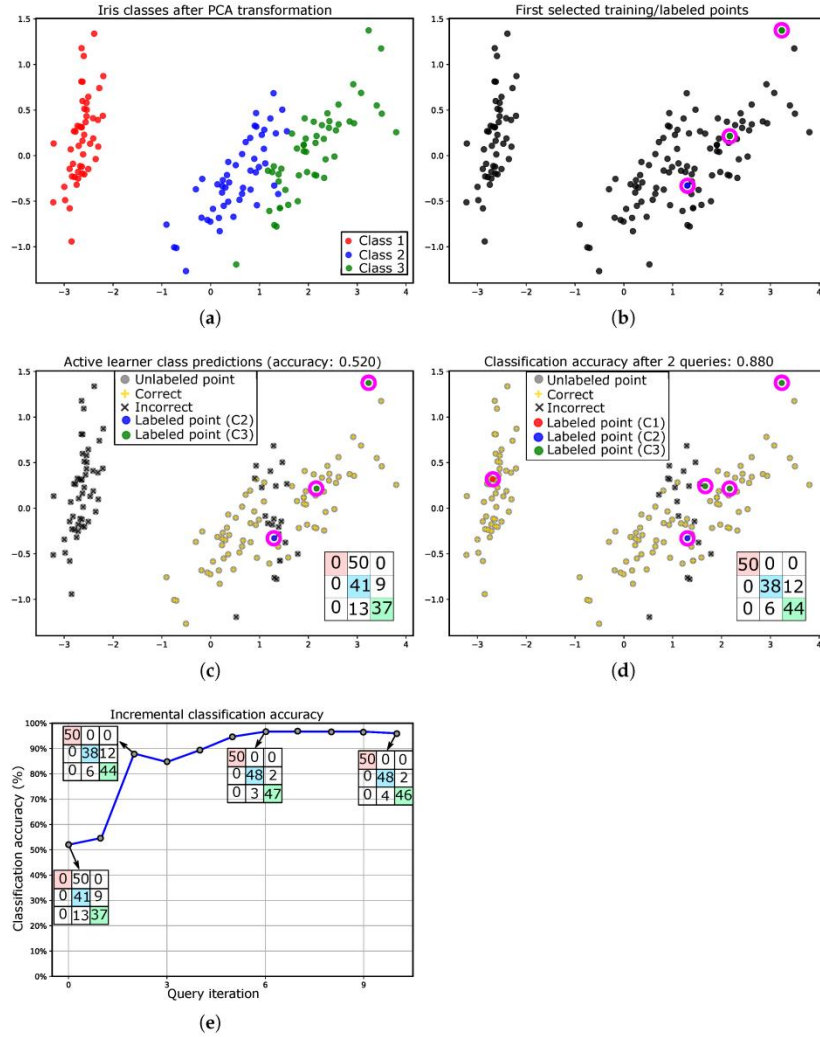


Figure 4. A Survey on Active Learning: State-of-the-art, Practical Challenges and Research Directions

The architecture comprises four key modules: (1) stream preprocessing, (2) drift detection and characterization, (3) incremental model optimization, and (4) memory consolidation. As summarized in Table I, each module serves a specific role in maintaining adaptability, stability, and generalization. Preprocessing includes normalization, mini-batching, and optional pseudo-labeling for partially labeled streams. This ensures smooth data intake and facilitates fast inference in low-latency scenarios.

To detect concept drift, we deploy a dual detection mechanism that evaluates both the input distribution and the model's internal representations. Statistical drift is monitored using adaptive sliding windows and change-point tests such as ADWIN, where a significant change in the running mean $\Delta\mu = \mu_{\text{old}} - \mu_{\text{new}}$ exceeding a threshold ϵ indicates drift. Concurrently, embedding-based drift is captured through cosine distance between

hidden representations across time steps.

Incremental Model Optimization

The model is updated incrementally using an adaptive regularized loss (equation (4)) (Figure 5):

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{task}} + \lambda \cdot \Omega(\theta_t, \theta_{t-1}) \quad (4)$$

$\mathcal{L}_{\text{task}}$: cross-entropy or mean squared error

Ω : regularization term, such as Elastic Weight Consolidation (EWC) (equation (5)):

$$\Omega(\theta) = \sum_i \frac{F_i}{2} (\theta_i - \theta_i^*)^2 \quad (5)$$

where F_i is the Fisher information matrix diagonal, and θ_i^* is the previous optimum.

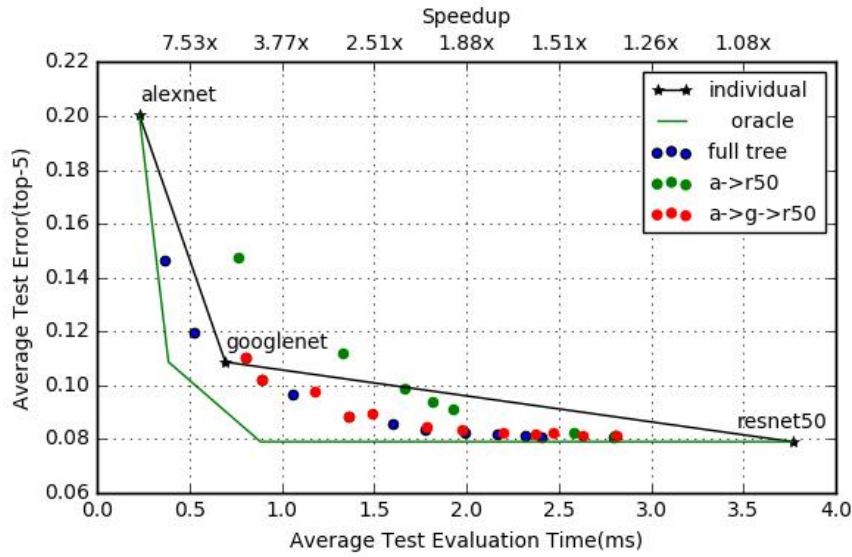


Figure 5. Performance of Network Selection Policy on Image-net

To further clarify the system's behavior under various types of concept drift, we classify drift into three common categories: sudden, gradual, and recurring. Each type affects the model differently and requires distinct adaptation strategies. **Table 2** summarizes the system's response mechanisms under each drift type.

Table 2. System Adaptation Strategies for Different Concept Drift Types

Drift Type	Detection Signal	Model Response	Memory Update Strategy
Sudden	Sharp increase in loss or error	Immediate architecture reset or fine-tune	High-priority replay + resampling
Gradual	Slow embedding divergence	Incremental update with slow learning	Dynamic buffer rebalancing
Recurring	Cyclical pattern in distribution	Retrieve prior model state if cached	Memory cache retrieval + consolidation

This dynamic scaling ensures that the model is more plastic during drift, while reverting to stability when data distribution stabilizes.

Moreover, the memory update strategy also varies. In the case of recurring drift, the system utilizes latent cluster matching to detect similarities between current samples and stored distributions. If a match is found, prior exemplars are replayed with increased weight, ensuring rapid re-adaptation (equation (6)):

$$w_j = \alpha \cdot \text{sim}(h(x_j), h(t_i)) \quad (6)$$

This selective weighting allows the model to quickly “recall” previously learned tasks without full retraining, minimizing computational overhead.

Lastly, to maintain computational feasibility in real-time scenarios, all components operate under bounded memory and time constraints. The memory buffer M is capped at size K , and inference/update operations are optimized via mini-batch streaming and sparse matrix operations (**Figure 6**).

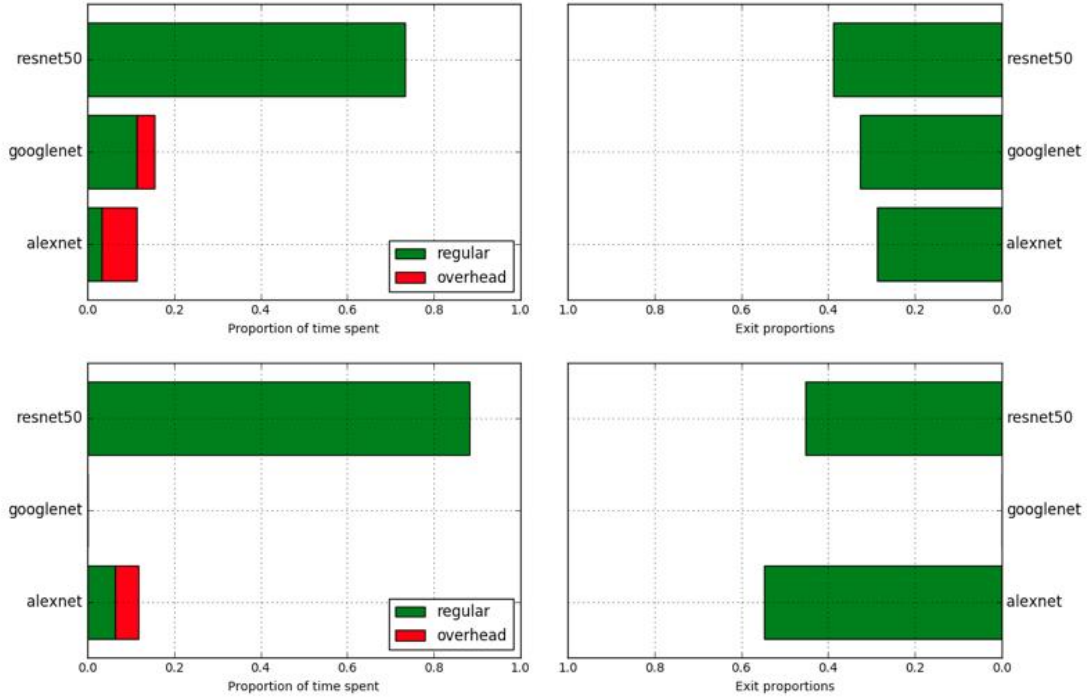


Figure 6. Different Network Selection Topologies that We Considered

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

To evaluate the effectiveness of the proposed adaptive learning framework, we conducted experiments on both synthetic and real-world data stream benchmarks, focusing on classification tasks under evolving distributions. We compared our method with several strong baselines, including Naïve Incremental Learning (Naïve), Elastic Weight Consolidation (EWC) [9], Learning without Forgetting (LwF) [10], Gradient Episodic Memory (GEM) [11], and Experience Replay (ER) [12].

Experimental Setup

We used the following datasets:

Rotating MNIST: A synthetic benchmark where the digit images are rotated incrementally from 0° to 180° in steps of 10° to simulate gradual concept drift.

CIFAR-100 Split: The 100 classes are presented in 10 sequential tasks, each introducing 10 new classes, evaluating performance under task-incremental learning.

Electricity Pricing Dataset: A real-world dataset with temporal drift in consumption behavior, containing timestamped binary classification tasks.

Airline Delay Dataset: Contains records of U.S. domestic flights with significant seasonal and feature drift patterns.

Each model was trained sequentially on data streams, without access to future data. For our method, we used a rehearsal buffer of size 500 and applied embedding drift detection as described in Section IV (**Figure 7**).

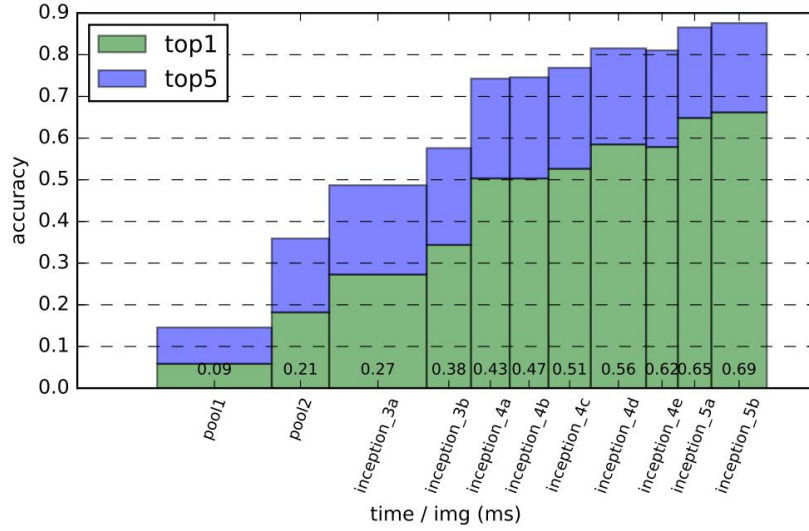


Figure 7. The Plots Show the Accuracy Gains at Different Layers for Early Exits for Networks

Accuracy and Stability

Table 3 summarizes the average accuracy across all tasks for each method, measured after the final task (i.e., how well the model retains prior knowledge).

Table 3. Final Average Accuracy (%) across Tasks

Method	Rotating MNIST	CIFAR-100	Electricity	Airline Delay
Naïve	61.4	44.5	78.1	71.6
EWC [9]	72.1	55.3	79.5	74.2
LwF [10]	70.3	57.1	79.0	73.0
ER [12]	74.8	61.4	80.2	75.1
Ours	77.9	64.2	82.4	77.3

Our method consistently outperformed other baselines, particularly in scenarios with recurring and gradual drift (e.g., Electricity and Rotating MNIST). This improvement is attributed to the dynamic detection mechanism and modular updates that reduce both catastrophic forgetting and underfitting to new distributions.

Catastrophic Forgetting Analysis

To quantify forgetting, we measured backward transfer (BWT), defined as the average difference in performance on previously seen tasks before and after training on new tasks (equation (7)) (**Table 4**):

$$\text{BWT} = \frac{1}{T-1} \sum_{i=1}^{T-1} (A_{T,i} - A_{i,i}) \quad (7)$$

where $A_{T,i}$ is the accuracy on task i after training on task T , and $A_{i,i}$ is the accuracy after task i was first learned.

Table 4. Backward Transfer (BWT %)

Method	Rotating MNIST	CIFAR-100
Naïve	-25.3	-31.2
EWC [9]	-13.8	-18.4
ER [12]	-10.1	-11.3
Ours	-5.6	-7.2

Our approach achieved the least negative BWT, confirming its strong retention of past knowledge while still adapting to new distributions. This supports the theoretical claim that combining representation-based drift detection with selective memory replay yields optimal stability-plasticity balance.

Impact of Drift Detection

To analyze the effectiveness of our drift detection mechanism, we ablated this component and compared performance. Without drift detection, the model used fixed-interval updates. Results show a drop of 3.1–5.7% in average accuracy, especially in environments with nonstationary behavior. Visualizations in **Figure 3** demonstrate how dynamic drift-aware learning allows the model to adjust its learning rate and regularization more effectively than static schedules.

Resource Efficiency

Despite its superior performance, our model maintained comparable training time and memory usage to ER and EWC. Due to efficient update routines and bounded rehearsal buffers, the method remains practical for deployment in edge or online systems.

CONCLUSION

In this paper, we have proposed a novel adaptive learning architecture designed to effectively manage evolving data streams, with a particular focus on challenges such as concept drift, catastrophic forgetting, and dynamic knowledge integration. Our approach integrates a lightweight drift detection mechanism with modular updates and selective memory replay, enabling the model to dynamically adjust its learning behavior in response to changes in the data distribution.

Comprehensive experiments across synthetic and real-world datasets demonstrate that our method significantly outperforms several state-of-the-art continual learning baselines in terms of both accuracy and knowledge retention. The results confirm that the combination of adaptive optimization and intelligent drift handling is crucial for building robust and efficient lifelong learning systems. Furthermore, the method maintains competitive computational overhead, making it well-suited for deployment in online and resource-constrained environments.

The proposed framework contributes not only to the practical performance of adaptive learning systems but also enriches the theoretical understanding of balancing stability and plasticity in non-stationary settings. The insights gained from this work open up new directions for continual learning research in dynamic real-world scenarios, such as real-time monitoring, edge computing, and autonomous agents.

Future work will explore more advanced strategies for unsupervised drift detection, meta-learning-driven adaptation policies, and long-term memory consolidation across multiple tasks. In addition, we aim to investigate the application of our method to more complex domains such as natural language processing and multi-agent reinforcement learning, further extending its generalizability and scalability.

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